

St. Paisios advice on how to help your brother:

1. Lead by Example, Not Lectures

“You cannot help your brother with words alone. If you want to pull him out of the mud, you must first stand on solid ground yourself.” *

“Live a life of prayer and repentance visibly, so he sees Christ in you. A good example is more powerful than a thousand sermons.” *

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 1: With Pain and Love for Modern Man

2. Avoid Judgement, Show Compassion

“Do not act like a Pharisee, counting his sins. Act like the Good Samaritan—bind his wounds with love.” *

“The sinner already feels shame. If you condemn him, you’ll drive him deeper into sin. If you show mercy, you’ll give him courage to repent.” *

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle

3. Pray Fervently for Him

“Your prayers for him are like ropes thrown to a drowning man. Even if he doesn’t grasp them yet, God uses them to keep him from sinking.” *

“Ask St. Moses the Ethiopian—a former violent sinner who became a great saint—to intercede for him.” *

*Oral tradition (recorded in "Words of Life")

4. Offer Practical Support

“Help him avoid near occasions of sin. If he struggles with lust, encourage fasting and less screen time. If it’s anger, teach him to pause and say the Jesus Prayer.” *

“Give him small, achievable spiritual goals—like reading one Psalm daily—so he doesn’t despair.” *

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 4: Family Life

5. Speak with Tact and Timing

“Correct him privately, gently, and only when he’s calm. A wounded soul rejects harsh medicine.” *

“Say, ‘I struggle too, but Christ helps me—let’s ask Him together.’ This humbles him without shaming him.” *

*Elder Paisios of Mount Athos: Epistles

6. Trust God’s Timing

“A farmer doesn’t dig up seeds to check if they’re growing. Plant the seeds of prayer and patience, then let God give the growth.” *

“Even if he falls a hundred times, God allows it to humble him. Your role is to keep lifting him up.” *

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 2: Spiritual Awakening

7. Warn Against Despair

“Tell him, ‘The devil wants you to think repentance is impossible. But Christ’s mercy is deeper than any sin.’” *

“Share stories of repentant saints (like St. Mary of Egypt) to give him hope.” *

*"Passions and Virtues" (Holy Monastery of St. Paisios)

Key Takeaway:

St. Paisios advises us to **combine spiritual warfare (prayer, fasting) with tangible love, while trusting God to soften the younger brother’s heart.

His approach avoids both permissiveness (“it’s no big deal”) and harshness (“you’re hopeless”), instead offering truth with mercy.

“A soul is saved not by force, but by love, patience, and much prayer.” *